



Figure 1: The VirtualBox home page just after its installation



Figure 2: Virtual Hard Disk selection

Figure 2.) As you click **Next** after selecting 'Create new hard disk', you get four options of creating one—VDI, VMDK, VHD or HDD. Let us understand each of these properly so that deciding on which one you want is easier. All four are nothing but disk image files.

- VDI or VirtualBox Disk Image is the container format for the guest OS used by VirtualBox itself. This format is used when a new virtual machine with a new disk is created.
- VMDK or Virtual Machine Disk is a file format that is an open container for virtual hard disk drives to be used in the virtual machine of the VirtualBox.
- VHD or Virtual Hard Disk is a file format used by Microsoft, which represents a virtual hard disk drive (HDD). It can contain files and folders and thus is used as a hard disk for the virtual machine.
- HDD or Parallels Hard Disk is a file format used by Mac to support all other OSs to run in it using VirtualBox.

Of all the file formats given above, it is advisable to create a new virtual machine VDI file. Select it and then select the virtual disk storage details. If you select 'Dynamically allocated' this will initially not occupy any space for unused virtual disk sectors, but will grow in size only when the guest actually stores data on its virtual hard disk sectors. It grows until it reaches the maximum capacity chosen when the drive was created. Now, even if we delete some files from the guest, the size doesn't



Figure 3: VirtualBox home page

decrease automatically; it still remains the size it had grown to. Here, write operations are a bit slower. In case of fixed size allocation, the file will immediately occupy the size specified, even if only a fraction of the virtual hard disk space is actually in use. This is slightly faster than a dynamically allocated file. So let us now fix the size of the disk. Click on **Next**, and you will be asked the virtual hard disk size to be allocated to the guest OS.

As you proceed, on the next page you will find the summary of the virtual disk file. Clicking on **Create** starts the process of creating a new virtual disk file. After the disk is created, click **Create** to create your first virtual machine. This will redirect you to the VirtualBox Manager home page, where on the left side panel you can see the VM you just created. You can change its settings through the 'Settings' tab. You will find your virtual machine in the powered-off state. After creating the virtual machine on your VirtualBox, your home page will look like the snapshot provided in Figure 3; start it as indicated.

When you click on **Start**, automatically a window appears. Select the drive in which your bootable media is, from where the setup program for the OS will be loaded. Install the OS you had specified during creation, i.e., insert your Fedora12 CD and get started. Install the OS as you would on your physical hard disk and get the feel of virtualisation. Once installed, you can easily use it along with the host OS of your physical computer. You can configure more virtual machines and install more OSs accordingly, on your VirtualBox, and use them along with your host OS. I do hope you liked the article—your feedback and queries are always welcome. **END**

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